

The Essence of Luxury

OPULENCE IS NOT GAWDY. IT IS SENSUAL, SUBTLE, CLASSY. HERE ARE FIVE EMBODIMENTS OF TRUE LUXE

PHOTOS AND TEXT BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

LIKE ANY TRUE ARTIST, Alok Lodha, 56, doesn't want to sell some of his jewellery pieces. These are pieces the fastidious second-generation jeweller—more a passionate gemstone collector really—works on for years and sometimes, even decades on end, to complete. Because he may not find the right intensity of the last two pink-red matching rubies (of the total 196 precious stones) to complete the five-string identically graded, antique necklace. Or because he may be fervently scouting sources around the globe to lay his hands on natural Basra pearls with the perfect lustre and exact size for the bracelet that he has sketched. On other occasions, he will not think twice about cutting a 51-carat emerald into almost half its size to fashion a rare hexagonal shape. Then there are gemstones in his collection so exquisite, like the gargantuan 185-carat emerald, which have the potential to become national treasures, let alone priceless heirlooms. His flagship store in Delhi's old-money alcove, Sundar Nagar, primarily displays jewellery created around gemstones of rare provenance and exquisite value. This ravishing necklace named **Greenesence**—priced at ₹1.5 crore—is fashioned around a deep green Colombian emerald weighing 35.09 carats. To cover a natural fissure in the middle of the stone, a 3.23-carat solitaire has been set on top of it in a unique kissing technique fashioned by round and oval cut diamonds weighing 43.67 carats. In painting terms, this would mean a one of a kind Cezzane canvas, where the painter deliberately painted a peach in the middle of his apples.

• MODEL **SHREYASI GOPINATH** • MAKE-UP ARTIST **KHUSHI JANGID**